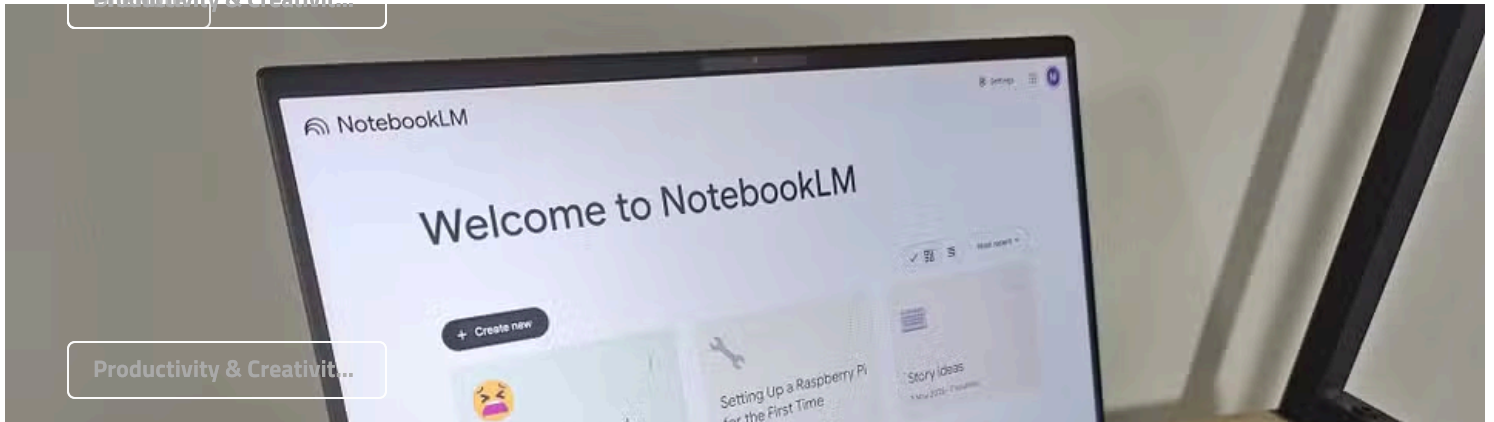


6 features NotebookLM does better than other alternatives

By Megan Ellis — 1 day ago



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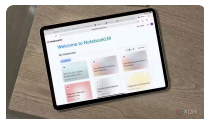
💬 Thread 3

Google's NotebookLM has proven to be a popular tool among note-takers for its powerful features and ability to summarize a variety of sources. While I prefer simple note-taking apps due to the drawbacks I experience from productivity apps, and I'm not a big fan of AI-powered features, NotebookLM manages to stand out by avoiding the pitfalls of many of its competitors.

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Here's a look at some of the features of NotebookLM that outpace its competition...

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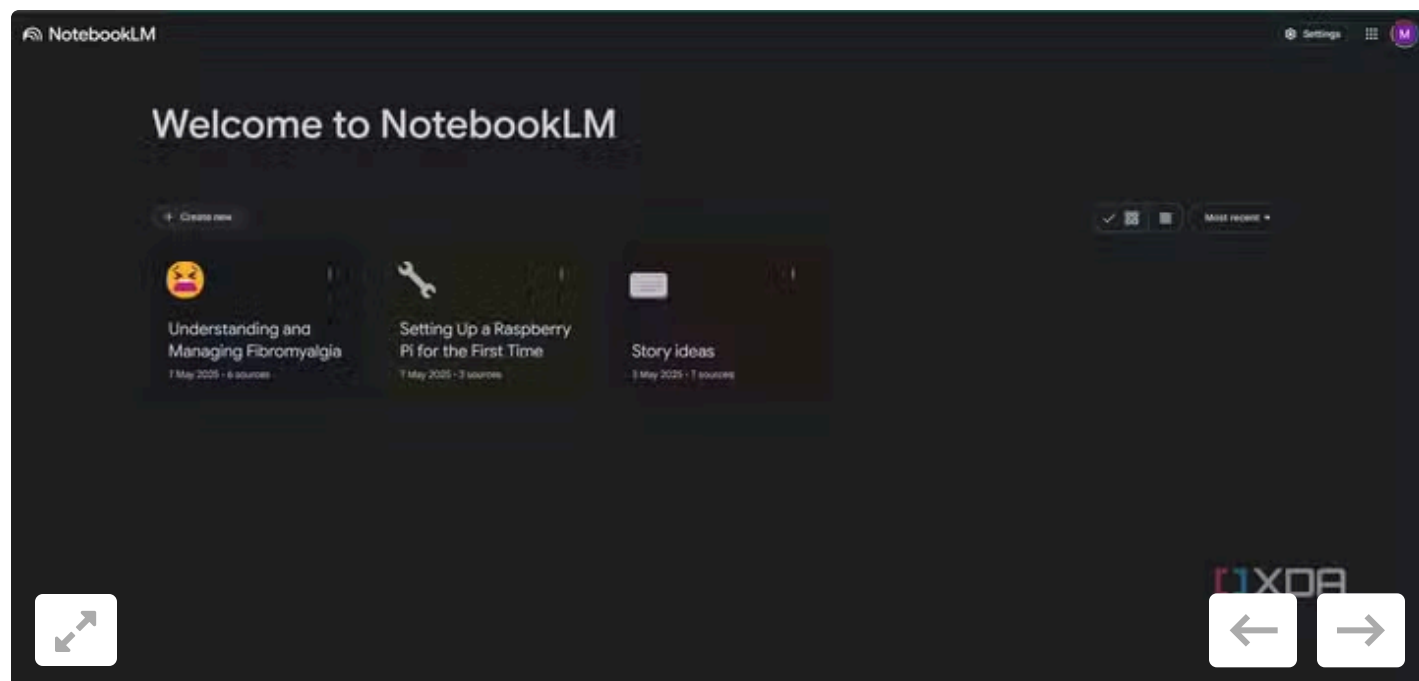


4 productivity tricks I've learned after using NotebookLM since launch day

6

A simple UI and suggested prompts

It's easy to get into



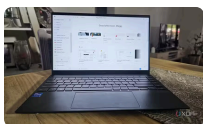
Productivity apps have made it easier to learn new things, but NotebookLM's simple UI and form really easy. When creating a notebook, the AI chat features suggest prompts to help you get started. These prompts also aren't generic prompts, but they are context-dependent and based on the sources you have uploaded. That said, using a unique, self-created prompt also works seamlessly.

Ad

Notebook LM's UI also puts its features front-and-center. This means you don't have to watch YouTube tutorials or visit help pages to learn how to use the app — you can see exactly what you can do from within your notebook.

That said, as NotebookLM introduces more features, it's possible that the platform becomes more complicated to use.

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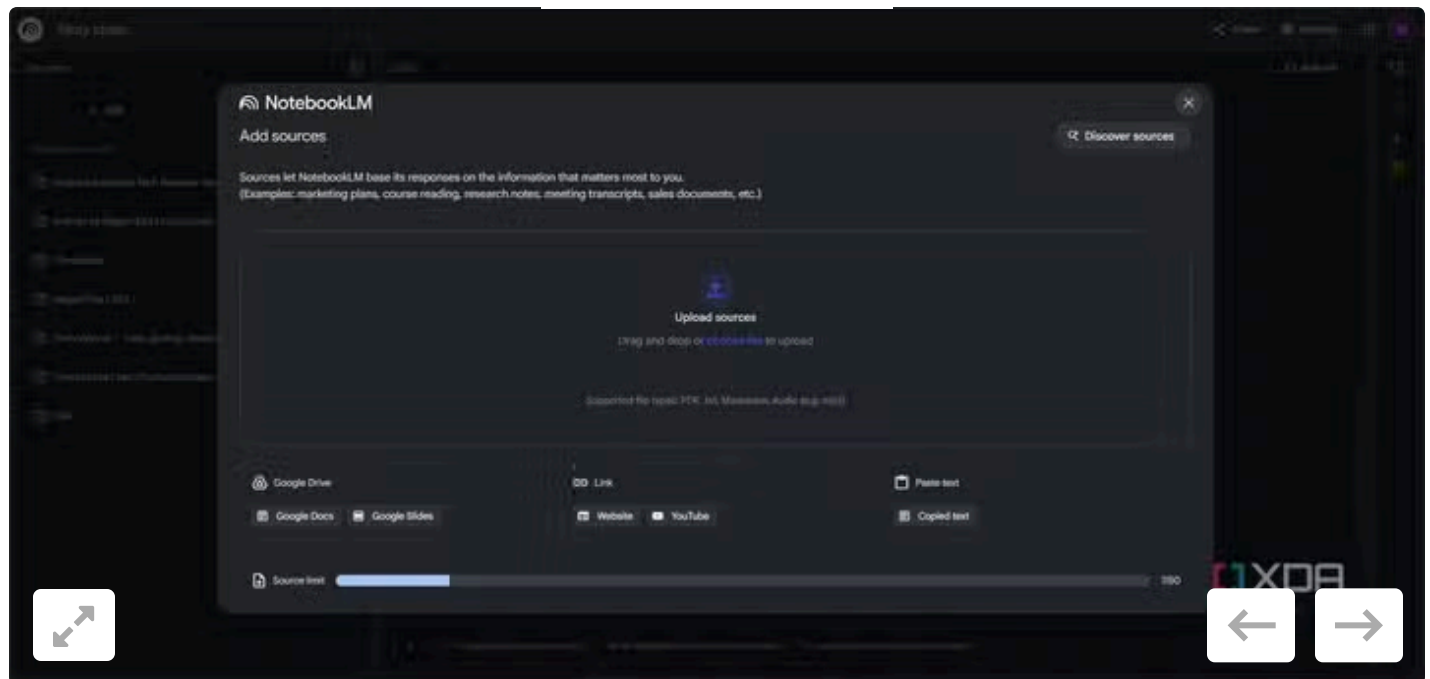
Notion is overwhelming but these 5 tips make it easier to use

5

Using specific sources

Choose the sources you want to use to generate answers

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One of the best features of NotebookLM is the ability to define the sources you want to use for responses. This is useful in a variety of ways. Firstly, you can make sure that only sources you trust are used. This is especially important when studying certain topics.

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Ad

Secondly, you can limit the scope of the results to consist of people with the same name. This means that the results on pages and profiles means that the results could use this to help me create a central author bio about myself, or use it to research interviewees for an article.

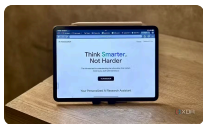
I Google myself, the results will show web sources to my own author information about other people. I

One limitation I found is that you cannot upload spreadsheets to NotebookLM. I wanted to see if I could get the platform to search through a list of conditions that are covered by South African medical aids. However, because the information was listed in a spreadsheet, NotebookLM couldn't use the information as a source. Even copying and pasting it as text without formatting did not work



The ability to define sources is one of the reasons people should try NotebookLM, even if they're skeptical of AI tools in general.

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I was missing out on these underrated NotebookLM features, and you probably are too

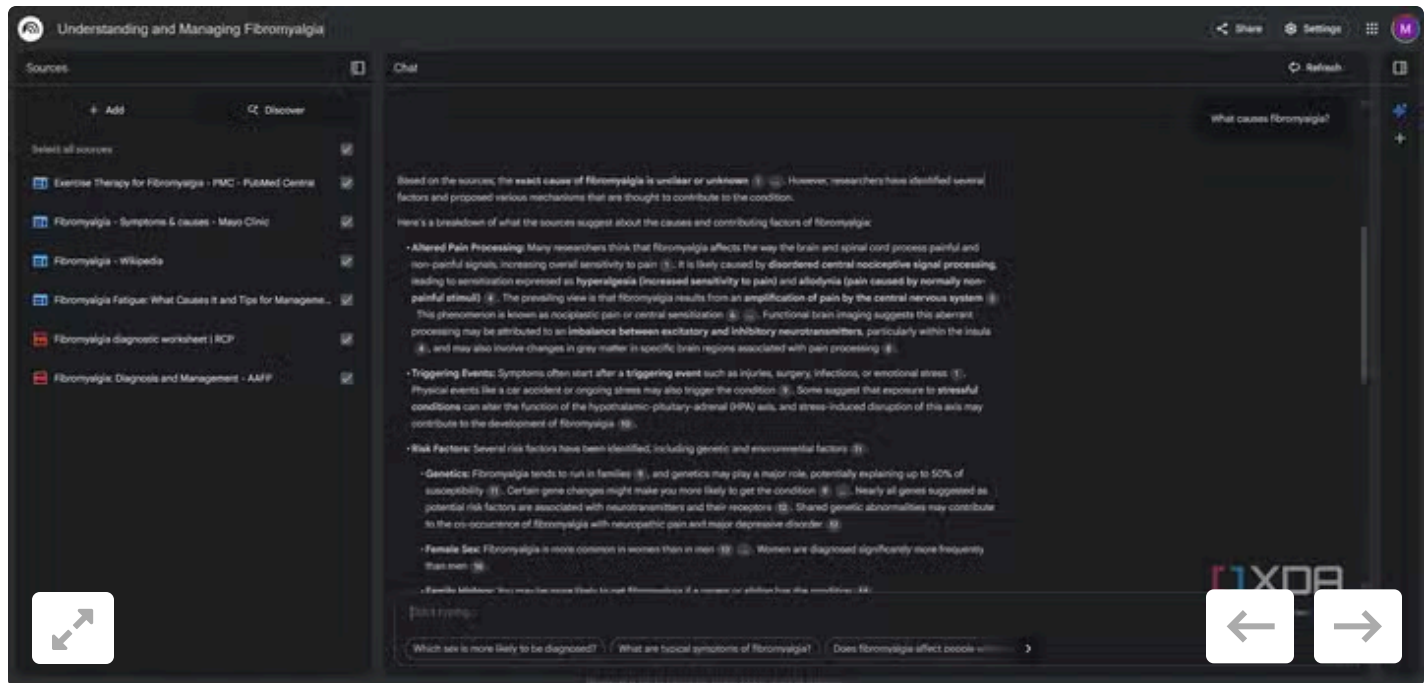
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Summation

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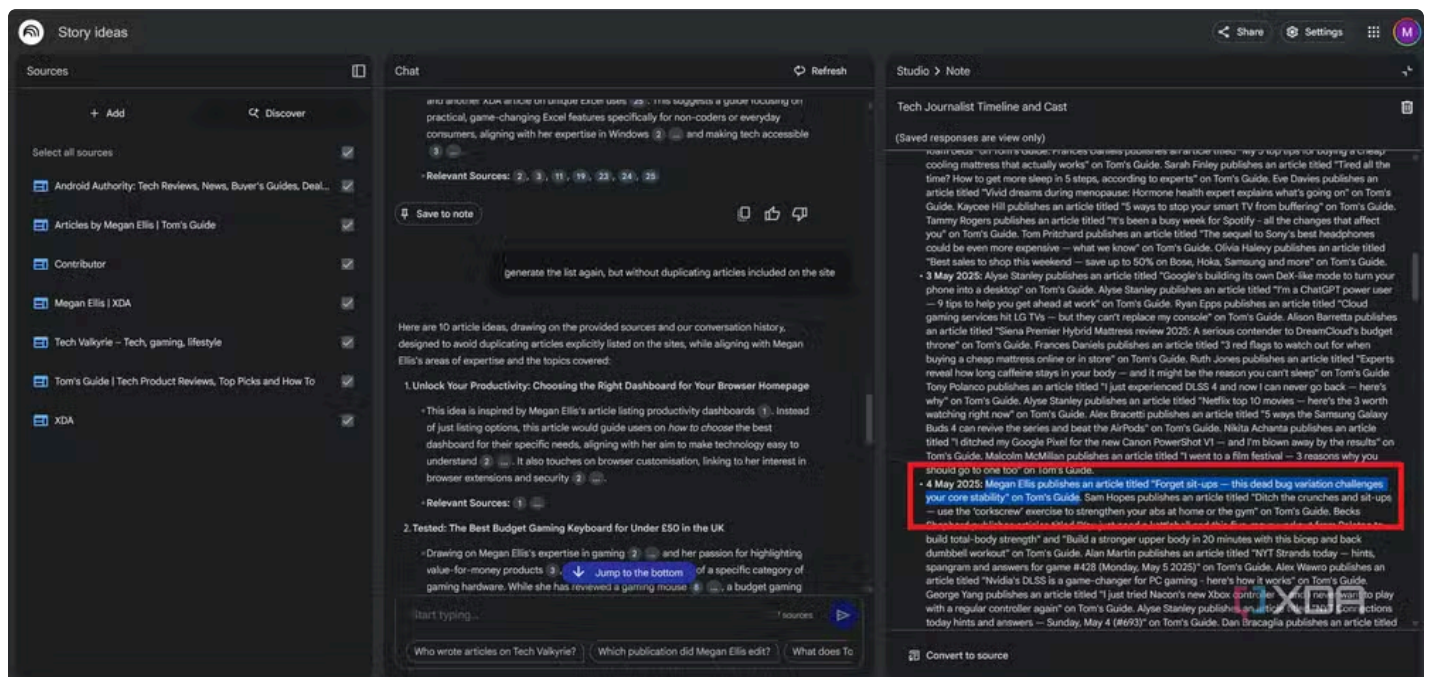
While NotebookLM's summaries can sometimes repeat information, the platform is generally great at providing an accurate summary of the sources that you've added to a specific notebook. While one of my notebooks is dedicated to generating story ideas, the sources also provide information about me and my expertise.

I decided to ask NotebookLM to tell me about myself. It was able to identify the profiles that applied to me, despite also including web pages that weren't directly related to me. All the information it included was accurate — it even pointed out a discrepancy in one of my online biographies where it says I started writing about technology in 2017 instead of 2016.

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The main hiccup is that it repeated some of my hobbies because I included different variations in some of my author bios. But overall, it is able to provide accurate summaries without making anything up.

I also tested the platform's accuracy when it comes to summarizing information about fibromyalgia. While I would never use AI to recommend medical treatment, I was curious to see if it could accurately provide insights about a condition I've been living with for over a decade. I was impressed by its ability to summarize information about it to answer questions about the causes and diagnostic criteria.



The caveat is that this accuracy di

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feature. I generated a timeline ba

websites I work for. The list starte

came up. The timeline said I published an article that I had not written. But other than

that, I didn't come across any other errors by the AI.

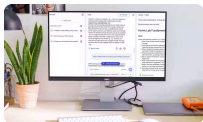
when it comes to the Timeline

es and the homepages of

but then eventually an error

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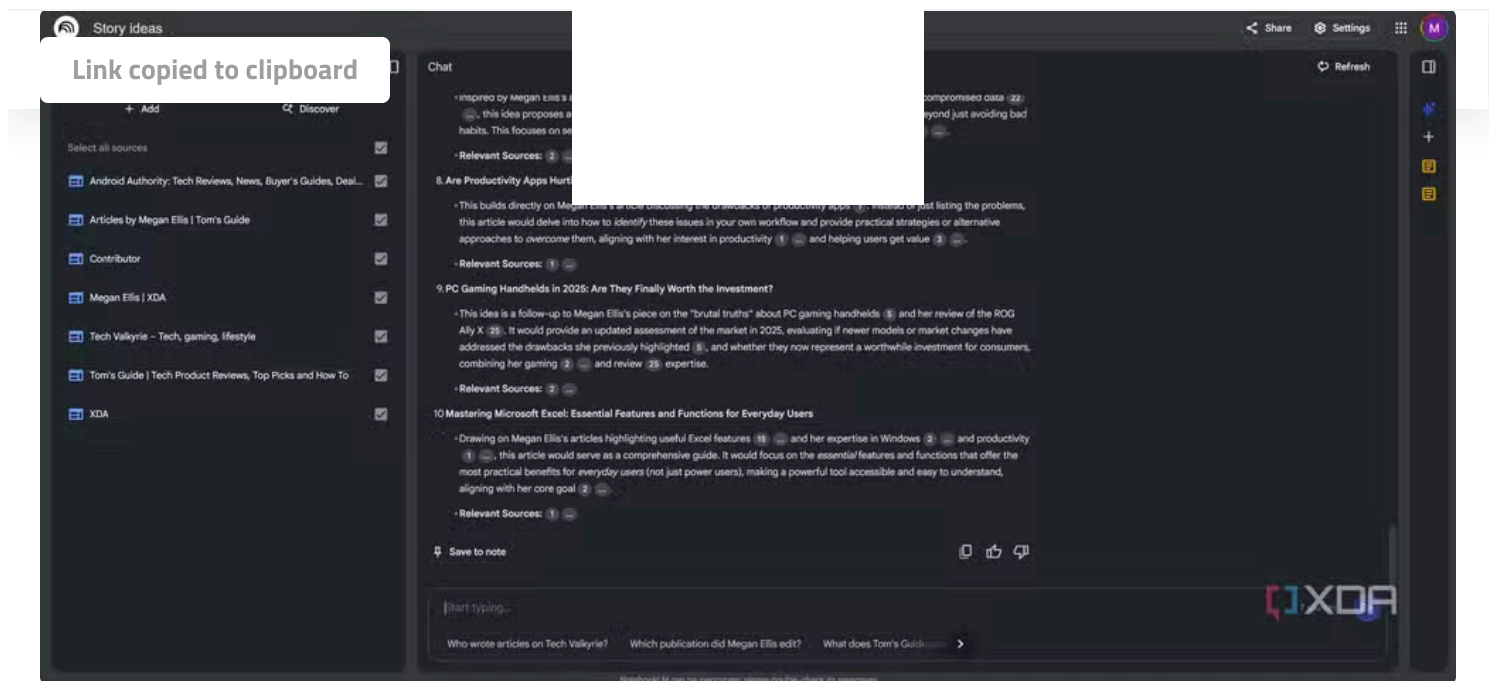


Forget Notion and Obsidian, 5 reasons Google's AI note-taking tool is the future of productivity

3

Generating ideas based on certain criteria

It actually uses the provided sources



People often tout AI tools as a way to generate ideas and inspiration. I write for a living, so I have no need for AI to write for me — but I could use help in generating ideas based on my own expertise and what the sites I work for cover.

I have tried to generate ideas with both LLM chatbots and AI note-taking tools — and every time, the responses are underwhelming. Tana's AI chat suggested I write about topics like cryptocurrency and the blockchain, even though the page I provided with ideas didn't list those topics.

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Meanwhile, when I've used tools I
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keep up to date with the latest g

st, the ideas are generic and don't
content.

NotebookLM has come the closest to providing usable ideas on topics I'm familiar with. The original list replicated too many ideas that I had already covered, but when I told it to exclude previous coverage, the list improved.

It still hasn't gotten to the point where it can outperform the idea generation of a writer with years of experience, but I imagine it would be useful for people who want to brainstorm ideas for topics they're less familiar with. I could also see how it would be useful for generating ideas for essays for students studying certain courses.

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I tried Tana, but here's why I'm sticking with Notion

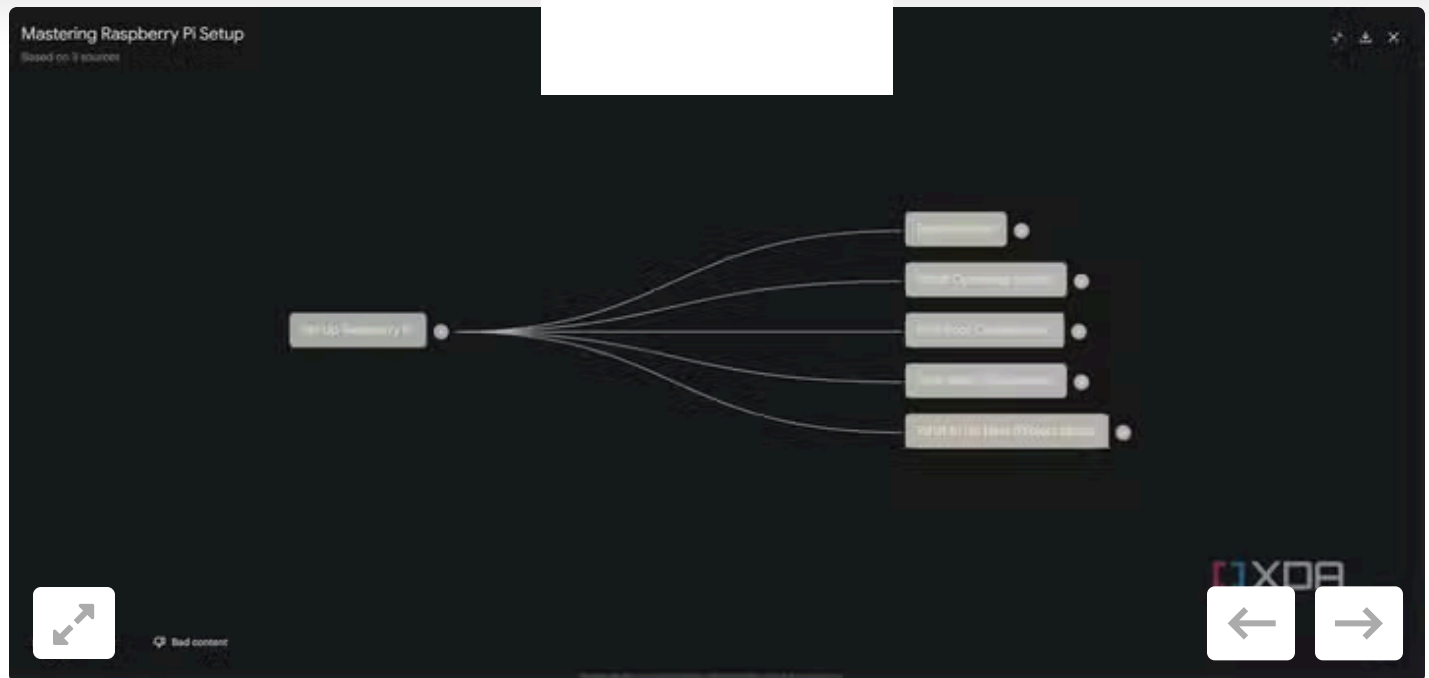
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2

Mind maps

Organization without the legwork

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I'm not usually a big fan of mind maps in productivity apps because they require you to structure your notes in a way that is conducive to the tree diagram format. You also usually have to create these mind maps yourself.

However, NotebookLM is able to seamlessly organize your sources and information into a mind map, even if you never intended to create one at first. For example, it took my sources on setting up a Raspberry Pi and organized them into different topics such as the requirements, installing an OS, and potential projects.

For my fibromyalgia notebook, it sorted the information into branches such as symptoms and prognosis.

These generated mind maps make it easy to work through the information you have added to your notebook without requiring any effort on your part. I find that this makes it extremely helpful while avoiding the learning curve or setup time that other platforms require.

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7 mind mapping apps I tested for business and personal use

1

Audio Overviews

Creating an interactive podcast from sources

The screenshot displays the XORA application interface, which is designed for creating audio overviews from various sources. The interface is divided into several sections:

- Sources:** A list of sources on the left, including "Exercise Therapy for Fibromyalgia - PMC - PubMed Central", "Fibromyalgia - Symptoms & causes - Mayo Clinic", "Fibromyalgia - Wikipedia", "Fibromyalgia Fatigue: What Causes It and Tips for Managing...", "Fibromyalgia diagnostic worksheet | RCP", and "Fibromyalgia: Diagnosis and Management - AAFP".
- Chat:** A central chat area with a "Refresh" button. It contains a message: "Discuss what these sources say about FM increasingly used, in the larger context of Terminology." Below this, a text box explains the etymology of "fibromyalgia" and a "Customise Audio Overview" section with a text input field.
- Studio:** A right-hand panel titled "Audio Overview" with a "Generate" button. It also includes a "Deep Dive conversation" section and a "Customise" button.
- Bottom Section:** A "Save to note" button, a "Generate" button, and a "What is a common symptom of fibromyalgia?" question.

The XORA logo is visible in the bottom right corner.

I was skeptical at first when it came to AI-generated videos or AI-generated audio. I've

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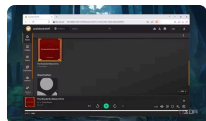
If there's not an outright error generating the material, then the output is marked by brevity and some unnatural interactions. Some have other drawbacks, the podcast hosts trying to mimic people with certain credentials, which I found misleading.

audio Overviews feature. Just like always something that gives away and podcast tools out of curiosity.

Ad

While Audio Overviews on NotebookLM do have the occasional uncanny moment, the feature still far outpaces other competitors. The overviews are in-depth while also making the material approachable. The hosts sound mostly natural, and I am often surprised by just how organic some of the responses sound.

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NotebookLM beats the competition in multiple ways

I approached NotebookLM with a skeptical eye and was pleasantly surprised by many of its features. You don't even have to opt for a paid plan to access features and can avoid many of the pitfalls of AI-powered tools by choosing your sources carefully. In many ways, the competition — both productivity platforms and LLM chatbots — could stand to

learn from NotebookLM. That said
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improve the platform.

es NotebookLM could add to



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Productivity &...

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THREAD 3

We want to hear from you! Share your opinions in the thread below and remember to keep it respectful.



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Sort by: Popular



Mike

2025-05-11 08:04:42

Save you spreadsheet as a PDF and upload it to NotebookLM, it works fine.



Copy



John

2025-05-11 04:55:54

Great to come across a South African tech reviewer. 😊

I can't wait for NotebookLM to support Google Sheets which would be a huge boost for NotebookLM. There is a kinda work around for spreadsheets, which is to export the sheet or workbook as a PDF and add that as a source.

If it's a spreadsheet you edit often, the only idea I know of for now is to 'live paste' the Sheets table into a Google Doc, add that doc as a source. Only drawback there is that when you update the table, you would have to sync the doc every time you update the table. I haven't tried it yet, but I'm sure one can set up an automated sync via a App Script or another way.



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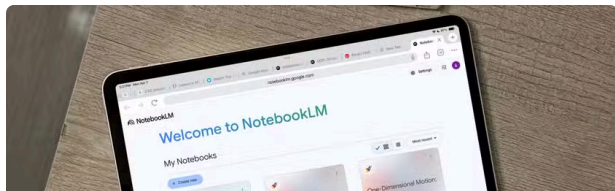
I like NotebookLM because it helps me organize and interact with my notes intelligently—it's like having a research assistant that actually understands my content.



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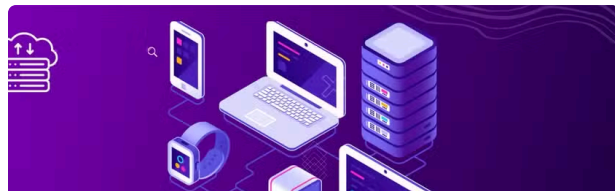
RECOMMENDED



NotebookLM might turn your notes into videos soon, and I'm all here for it

NotebookLM's Audio Overviews were clearly just the beginning

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Self-hosting doesn't have to be scary, and I use these 4 tools without any...

Unlock self-hosting power without learning to code

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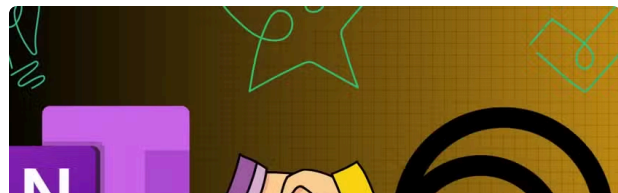
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7 Docker containers I wasted time trying to use (and what I did instead)

Docker containers I gladly replaced

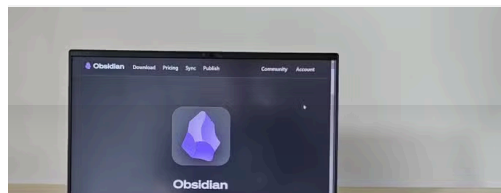
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I started using NotebookLM with OneNote and here's how it went

NotebookLM meets OneNote

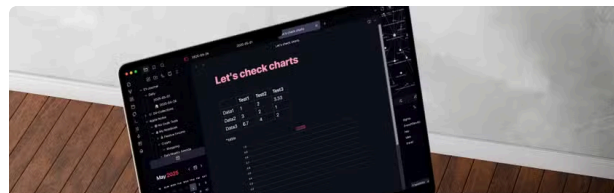
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I self-hosted Obsidian so that I can access it in my web browser anywhere...

Your notes will always be with you

8 hours ago



I made my own Obsidian Sync server with my NAS and a free plugin, and it...

It's arguably better than Obsidian Sync, too.

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